

GROWTH

Unlike other roleplaying games, Cairn does not reward player characters for killing monsters, looting treasure, or exploring new places. Instead, it is a character's unique experience in the game world that has the potential to alter their health, abilities, beliefs, bonds, and even their minds.

Just as the in-game world continues to grow and change, so do the player characters. The events, experiences, and encounters of a play session can greatly impact a PC, sometimes in undesirable ways! Keep in mind however that with some notable exceptions (such as *Scars*), growth should always stem from a character's experiences in the game world. Character growth can also depend on the results of Downtime procedures that help a character focus on training or specialization, research, and faction relationships.

PRINCIPLES FOR GROWTH

- ♦ Growth is never arbitrary, but is tied to a specific experience happening in the fiction.
- ♦ It is more important for a character to become more interesting than to become more skilled or capable.
- ♦ Characters experience growth not simply because they've had a new experience but because that experience has affected them a significant way.
- ♦ Place opportunities for growth in as many places as possible.
- ♦ Characters grow as often during a play session as they do during Downtime.
- ♦ Growth should foster further interaction with the game world and its challenges.
- ♦ Growth is not a reward but the logical result of a character's actions.
- ♦ Growth happens most often when a character interacts with something they do not understand or something they were not *meant* to understand.
- ♦ Characters may change in a way that they don't like or may gain new abilities at a cost.
- ♦ Relics, treasure, factions, monsters, and important NPCs are all excellent potential triggers for growth.
- ♦ Characters can change slowly over time or by amassing significant, cumulative experiences around a single type of growth.

TRIGGERS: A FRAMEWORK FOR GROWTH

As characters engage with the game world, they must increasingly adapt to new realities in the fiction. Some of these adaptations are minor and rarely revisited again. Others are cumulative, representing a collection of related experiences. And some experiences are so powerful that their impact is immediate and unparalleled. For each of these it can be helpful to assign *Triggers*, or opportunities for growth. These represent significant turning points in a character's life and should be met with a permanent and related change! Good triggers depend on characters engaging in at least two of the following:

- ♦ A focused, consistent pattern of behavior around a single objective or course of action.
- ♦ Taking an obvious risk with potentially serious consequences, especially when the outcome is unknown.
- ♦ Interacting with a unique item, creature, or entity.

INTERACTING WITH SOMETHING (OR SOMEONE) THEY DO NOT UNDERSTAND

Esme and her comrades were tasked with rescuing a merchant and his daughter that had disappeared into the Moon Hill Woods. On the way, Esme stumbled upon a fallen tree, struck by lightning. Daring to climb inside, she discovered a glowing, egg-shaped object: a Heartseed. Recognizing its value (but not its purpose), she took the seed, ignoring the mumblings of her friends. Over the next few days, Esme noticed crows wherever she went: in the boughs, in the sky, on the trail. Late one night, she had a vision of a terrifying creature built from grass and twigs gazing deep into her soul. She awoke frightened, but kept the visions to herself. She decided to keep the Heartseed, no matter what. Over the coming days, her visions increased in severity and regularity, as did the crows, which now appeared even in town, perched on roofs and doorways. Resolute, she ground the seed into bits with a hammer, then swallowed the resulting mess with water. Only then did the visions cease and the crows disappear. The following day, her skin began to turn green, and small twigs were sprouting from her elbows and chin. Seeking advice from a Bog Witch she'd met in an earlier encounter, she was told that by consuming the Heartseed she had committed herself to the Wood, and that she would soon be bound to the forest forever. She would no longer consume rations, only sunlight and water. She would hear the words of the Wood, as well as the plants and animals that live there. But the witch said that there was a way out, and all that she required was a drop of Esme's blood...

In this scenario Esme made a series of decisions that quickly spiraled out of control: the choice to take the Heartseed despite her friend's warnings, ignoring the crows, disregarding the visions pleading with her to return it, and then finally the decision to ingest the seed itself.

LONG-TERM EXPOSURE OR MANIPULATION OF A SPELLBOOK OR RELIC

*Throughout her adventures, Hazel made frequent use of a Control Plants Spellbook she'd "borrowed" from the abbey where she grew up. Often she would attempt to enhance its power, making WIL saves each time to expand its reach. Of course, not every attempt was successful, and occasionally she paid a heavy price. On one occasion, she and her companions were exploring a jungle temple and stumbled upon a horrific creature made entirely of plant matter. Seeing an opportunity to use the creature's strengths against it, Hazel's allies gathered around her while as she read from the Spellbook. The Warden then asked for a WIL save, as she was trying to cast the spell quickly and under duress. A success! The Warden declared that going forward, she would be able to read from her Spellbook while under duress or time pressure **without** first making a successful WIL save.*

Hazel had previously made multiple attempts to bend the Spellbook to her will with mixed results. She also took a major risk when she tried to cast the spell quickly, and as Spellbooks are unique items of great power, this made her success despite that risk all the more impactful.

FORGING A RELATIONSHIP WITH A BEING OF GREAT POWER

Aster and his comrades came upon a shrine deep hidden in a forest cave. After some research and experimentation (spearheaded by Aster), they were able to free the nearly-mad river god trapped within. As thanks, the deity offered its unknowable essence to anyone willing to receive it. Aster stepped forward and was bound to the god, forgoing his old life and adopting a new religion. A few days later, gills sprouted from Aster's neck after an impromptu dive in a raging river.

Through his attempts to interact with the statue and determine its true purpose, Aster revealed a distinct pattern of behavior, and although the results were uncertain, he still took a serious risk by prostrating himself to an entity he did not know or understand.

OVERCOMING A LONG-TIME WOE, MISDEED, OR FOE

At long last, Oxrable Kinter (or Ox) had finally defeated the serial murderer Tibor Heimshern. But instead of killing him, Ox used the Spirit Siphon to pull the prone man's consciousness straight out of his body. Then to the surprise of everyone at the table, Ox proceeded to drink the man's spirit. The Warden called for a WIL save to overcome Tibor's powerful essence: a success! The Warden then asked the player to reroll Ox's Willpower attribute, saying he could keep the results if they were higher. And they were! However, the Warden also ruled that if at any point Ox had another enemy weak and at his mercy, a WIL save would be required to overcome the murderer's dormant tendencies within his psyche.

Through the dogged pursuit of his powerful enemy, Ox demonstrated a distinct pattern of behavior. Drinking the spirit of Tibor represented a clear risk to Ox, and even though the Spirit Siphon was a known Relic, its ability to move souls between hosts was an obvious case of interacting with an object not fully understood.

INJURY OR CONTAMINATION

After days of searching, Madrigal the Fungal Forager had finally found the source of bellowing sickness that had stricken an impoverished village: a Liverbracket infestation at the bottom of the town's well. It took many hours of diligent work to uproot the fungi network, but in the end, Madrigal left the town in good spirits, his pockets heavy with gold. He then embarked on a ten-day journey across the Lava Flats in search of a Gate he'd heard about. A week later, he noticed a strange discoloration on his canteen, and cutting it open, he discovered that he'd been drinking Liverbracket-tainted water! Strangely, he'd been unaffected by the side-effects common to ingesting the fungus. The Warden explained that this was likely because its effects were being counteracted by Madrigal's overcautious intake of Clustermelon Flower, a potent form of heat resistance, useful when crossing the Lava Flats. He spent a few hours fashioning a new canteen, then set out again. Two days later, Madrigal noticed a series of small bumps on his skin, along with a familiar discoloration. Stranger yet, he'd completely lost his appetite for Rations. The Warden ruled that going forward Madrigal would no longer need to eat typical food but instead could subsist only on decomposed plants and animals. However, if he would ever be drenched in water, he must take a Fatigue, expelling spores the following day.

This example involved only a minor risk, but the interaction between two unique items (the fungus and the flower) were powerful enough to justify a sort of *passive* growth experience. However, it was Madrigal's thoughtful (albeit potentially unnecessary) decision to ingest Clustermelon Flower that acted as the true Trigger in this instance.

LEARNING THROUGH TRIAL AND ERROR

Julius was bookish, nervous, and not particularly strong or dexterous. Over months of adventuring, he had developed a strategy to avoid direct confrontation in combat, which involved throwing a weighted net onto an opponent. While the target was prone and defenseless, Julius, without adequate protection from his allies, would be at high risk, especially when facing multiple opponents. Each time Julius attempted this, his player would need to explain exactly how he approached his target, and if the obvious risks weren't mitigated, the Warden would require a DEX save to succeed. After a particularly risky attempt failed, all of the players (including the Warden) were so impressed by the care and strategy that went into the attempt that the Warden ruled that going forward, Julius would no longer need to make a save when throwing the net in combat. Instead, it would succeed automatically, as Julius had clearly learned how to capture targets in his net safely.

In this example, we can see that although Julius had occasionally failed in his repeated attempts to avoid direct combat by employing a unique battle strategy, the thought and preparation that went into each attempt and the character's insistence to "get it right" were sufficient to grant that character a new ability. Remember that in a typical combat scenario, the PCs have already rolled DEX saves at the beginning of combat, so future DEX saves are really only required when a character puts themselves at further risk through an act of bravery, tries to flee combat, etc. A save isn't necessarily required from the target of an action either, as only the character *most at risk* saves.

SUCCESS OR FAILURE DESPITE A NATURAL TALENT OR ABILITY

*Harrow and his comrades were pursuing a group of brigands led by a notorious werewolf. They'd followed the criminals back to their hideout, approaching at dawn when the outlaws would hopefully still be sleeping off the previous night's activities. Harrow led the party carefully alongside the camp, hoping to slip in silently. This proved to be more difficult than anticipated, as the brigands had posted guards at four separate outposts. The Warden ruled that as Harrow was leading the group **and** had the worst natural ability (his player had rolled a measly 5 DEX), he should make the save the party required to sneak in undetected. He succeeded, and the Warden declared that going forward, the Warden would no longer require Harrow to save DEX in similar situations, due to his character clearly having a natural affinity for sneaking.*

Here is a clear example of a character working against type. The Warden deemed that despite Harrow's relatively low DEX, his decision to lead the party coupled with his ultimate triumph were sufficient triggers for growth.

FACTION ADVANCEMENT

Three weeks ago, Rui was tasked by the **Order of the Helm** with locating a Gate in the Wyskat Forest. She returned earlier than expected, having completed her mission with great aplomb. Her employers were so impressed with her work that she was formally invited to join The Order as an **Initiate**. The Warden explained that the position had no distinct requirements but paid a regular stipend and came with some fraternal benefits. The only requirement would be that she complete occasional tasks on behalf of the Order in pursuit of its cause. If she were to later pursue a higher-level rank, she would be required to formally pledge allegiance to the Order and take their Oath. Rui agrees to join as an Initiate for now, and the Warden describes the Downtime **Milestones** that track Rui's relationship with The Order:

- ♦ Complete one mission on behalf of the order.

- ♦ Complete two missions on behalf of the order.

- ♦ Complete three missions on behalf of the order.

- ♦ Train with a **Protector**.

- ♦ Take the Oath.

The Warden explains that Rui would be provided with a uniform, a shield (+1 Armor), and a fine short sword (d6). Along with the support she would receive at any faction outpost, she would also receive a stipend of 5gp per day while working on faction-related business. She would also be required to check in with a local **Precept** whenever possible. A few sessions later, The Order asks Rui for her assistance with an escort through the **Falal Swamps**. The entire party joins the mission, and despite a near-fatal encounter with a bog demon, the mission is completed successfully. Rui's player marks off the second **Milestone**, as she'd already completed the first prior to joining the faction.

Months go by, and Rui completes two more missions and trains with a Master from The Order. She learns both focus and swordsmanship, increasing her HP and the damage she delivers with a sword. She also learns the faction's true objective and decides their cause is just. She dons an iron helm (+1 Armor, petty) and takes their Oath, accepting that she can never again reveal her face to any living creature so long as she lives. The Warden explains that although Rui still required food, water, and sleep, she no longer becomes deprived from that lack of them.

This example relies on activities that occur both in the game and between sessions, utilizing two separate Downtime procedures (*Strengthening Ties* and *Training*). The **Protector** that Rui trained with acted as Master, and although we don't describe it here, there was likely a second tier of **Milestones** included in that aspect of her journey.

RESOLUTION OF A BOND OR OMEN

Cursed with a Stone Heart after running afoul of a pack of forest druids, Cobb was desperate for a cure. After months of adventuring, it had grown quite heavy, and so his player asked the Warden if he could spend a Downtime action researching a potential cure. The Warden provided the following **Milestones**:

- ♦ Find a Master. Typically that would be a witch, scholar, healer, or powerful spirit.

- ♦ Search out the Master and ask their requirements.

- ♦ Complete these requirements to cure the Stone Heart.

*Cobb spent a few days between adventures talking to local healers and scholars to no avail. Eventually he met a local tracker they'd hired who admitted she'd once seen a Woodwose deep in the forest nearby. In her story, she had tracked a large boar to a silver pool beneath a waterfall. It was there she saw it leap into the water and disappear. Moments later it rose again, but now it had taken the shape of a large man covered in thick green hair. She dropped her weapons and bag, placing them in front of her. The creature stepped from the water, then took some of her dried jerky and left. She said the next day she noticed that an old injury she'd been nursing had completely healed and that it was the Woodwose that had done it. The tracker offered to, for a price, take Cobb and his friends to the pond. He agreed, and the following day they set out to find the Woodwose from her tale (and his player marked off a **Milestone**). In the coming weeks, Cobb and his friends found the creature and won its favor, completing various tasks throughout the Wood. In the end, the Woodwose offered each character a Boon, and Cobb was able to finally rid himself of the curse.*

Cobb's player had rolled a **15** on the Bonds table during character creation, which reads: *You crossed a creature of the Wood, and it cursed you with a Stone Heart (1 Armor). With each passing month, the stone grows heavier by one slot. Until your debt is lifted, you cannot truly die.* In order to cure this illness, he must research the location of a Master, then engage them in a bargain. Fortunately he'd made connections with a hireling the party had utilized in past woodland jaunts, who was more familiar with the nearby Wood and its denizens.